special materials and attention to develop fully.

Causes of Visual Impairment

Visual impairment can be caused by the following factors:

a. Congenital Blindness:

It refers to a child being born blind.

b. Acquired Blindness:

In this case the child is not born blind. The child may lose eye-sight on account of some accident. The resulting eye-defect is called acquired blindness.

c. Nutritional blindness:

It is a result of prolonged absence of vitamin-A rich foods in the diet. Deficiency of vitamin-A causes dryness of eyes, (xerophthalmia) and impaired vision in dim light (night blindness).

Special Needs of a Visually Challenged Child:

Physical Needs:

Parents of a visually challenged children have to give special attention and train their children to do their daily routine jobs like toilet, bath, dressing and feeding etc. Special effort is needed to help them to move around the house without knocking things and hurting themselves.

Emotional and Social Needs:

Parents and siblings need to develop social contact and provide constant reassurance by hugging, petting and reassuring the handicapped child when scared and emotionally upset.

Educational Needs:

Books with big print and a desk with proper light and recorded tapes are of considerable help to the child with defective vision. The special tool called "Braille" is also helpful. The Braille dots are punched out one at a time from right to left. Children learn to use Braille with ease once coached properly.

DO YOU KNOW?

White cane day is celebrated worldwide on October 15th every year. This is celebrated to create awareness and celebrate the importance of the white cane used by visually challenged people.

2.2.4.2 Hearing Impairment

Definition

A child with hearing impairment is one who has lost the sense of hearing before learning the language. This means that the child is born without the ability to hear. Such children are often mute and silent.

Hard of hearing on the other hand is a defect that is acquired later in life. The child experiences varying degrees of hearing loss.

Causes of hearing impairment

Hearing impairment and loss can be due to the following factors:

(a) Conductive hearing impairment

The passage of air in the outer ear is called the 'Conductive Pathway'. The conductive pathway can get affected due to

i. Build up of wax in the ear,
ii. A foreign body in the pathway
iii. Any swelling of the outer ear.

These conditions can cause temporary hearing impairment that can be medically treated.

(b)*Sensory Neutral hearing loss* is due to the damage of the ear drum, cochlea, auditory nerve and the associated brain cells.

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